Panjshiri leader told X that Massoud went through an image makeover and tried to portray himself as the Che Guevara of Afghanistan. But with his wife and family, he was very conservative. Even Rabbani, whom India portrayed as the legitimate leader of Afghanistan, was 'close to Pakistan and could not have been trusted,' says X.[32] Rabbani's men may be fighting Pakistan and the Taliban, but he himself had very strong links with Pakistan and had sent his family to live in Pakistan. Critically, the UF had its own share of human rights violations that the UN and Human Rights Watch actively condemned.[33] Knowing this, India sheltered families of Abdullah and Qanooni (among various other leaders) and gave them personal and political space, all on Indian government funds.[34]

Abdullah closely facilitated India's relations with the UF and helped New Delhi build political constituencies in north and west Afghanistan. India's attempt to provide these leaders with an option other than Pakistan reaped political rewards for years to come. Critically, compatible with Indian political traditions, the UF was portrayed as a 'secular nationalist face of Afghanistan,' in contrast to the Taliban's fundamentalism.[35] Dostum and Mohaqiq's excesses, and also those of Massoud, were largely written-off as wartime politics, whereas the Taliban remained pariah. As A. S. Dulat, the R&AW's chief in 1999–2000, says, 'while I was heading R&AW, we didn't try to reach out [to the Taliban] because we were so hooked onto the Northern Alliance, but then everything changed once the top Alliance military person, Ahmed Shah Masood, was killed'.[36] India had not built any credible alternatives to play a decisive role in Afghanistan. Its approach, despite being politically partisan, had all the markers of 'dependence' on the UF. Such partisanship, argues Dulat, was in fashion at that time. 'Masood's death narrowed down our [Indian] options ... [but] the thing is that this game was similar to what we were doing in Kashmir in 1988 and 89, when we were hooked to Farooq Abdullah' but neglected other Kashmiri leaders, 'which wasn't very smart'.[37] One may think that one has the best person, but that is often not the end of matter, argues Dulat. Not surprisingly, Massoud's assassination two days before 9/11 came as a major shock to India.[38]

India had developed close links with the *Jamiat-e-Islami* and Haji Qadir, a powerful Pashtun leader from east Afghanistan, even before the UF came into being.[39] Once the UF was formed, India automatically chose to support it